

LEAP 2025

English Language Arts Practice Test Grade 8

Session 1

Literary Analysis Task and Reading Passage

Directions:

Today you will take Session 1 of the Grade 8 English Language Arts Practice Test.

Read each passage and question. Then follow the directions to answer each question. Mark your answers by **circling** the correct choices in your test booklet. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

One of the questions will ask you to write a response. Write your response in the space provided in your test booklet.

If you do not know the answer to a question, you may go on to the next question. If you finish early, you may review your answers and any questions you did not answer in this session **ONLY**. Do not go past the stop sign.

GO ON ►

Today you will analyze passages from two novels. As you read these texts, you will gather information and answer questions about the characters and points of view so you can write an analytical essay.

Read the passage from the novel *Confetti Girl*. Then answer questions 1 and 2.

from *Confetti Girl*

by Diana López

- 1 Mom always had after-school projects waiting for me. “Can you help decorate cookies?” she’d say. Or, “Go outside and pick some flowers.” Or, “Fix my nails, please.” She loved to paint them, but since she wasn’t coordinated with her left hand, her right-hand nails looked like a preschooler’s coloring page.
- 2 I guess these projects were chores, but they were fun, too. Now when I come home, I’ve got to sweep, fold towels, or scrub the bathroom sink. Dad helps, but sometimes he makes a big mess.
- 3 Like today. He’s got flour, potato skins, and crumpled napkins on the counter. The pot boils over with brown scum. And I don’t want to talk to him because I’m still mad about the volleyball game, but I have to know what he’s up to.
- 4 “What are you doing, Dad?”
- 5 “Making dinner. Thought I’d give you a break.”
- 6 Except for game nights, dinner’s my responsibility. I cook while Dad cleans—that’s our rule. And even though I don’t cook as well as Mom did, Dad never complains.
- 7 “What are you going to make?” I ask.
- 8 “*Carne guisada* and *papas fritas*.”
- 9 “You need a recipe for that?”
- 10 “Are you kidding? I need a recipe for peanut butter sandwiches.”
- 11 How mad can a girl be at a man who makes fun of himself and wears a green frog apron that says KISS THE COOK and tube socks over his hands for potholders?

GO ON ►

- 12 We clear space on the table. Dinner's served. The beef's tough and the *papas* are mushy, but who cares? I pretend it's delicious because my dad lets me blabber about the Halloween carnival. He laughs out loud when I describe Vanessa's potato baby and Ms. Cantu's creative *cascarones*,¹ so I don't complain when I notice he served ranch-style beans straight from the can instead of heating them up first.
- 13 Everything's great until he asks about my English class.
- 14 "Any new vocabulary words?" he wants to know.
- 15 "I guess. Maybe. Super . . . super . . . super something. Can't remember."
- 16 "Was it *supersede*?" he asks. "*Supercilious? Superfluous?*"
- 17 "I don't remember, Dad. It could have been *super-duper* or *super-loop* for all I care."
- 18 He gets sarcasm from his students all the time so he's good at ignoring it.
- 19 "Remember that *super* is a prefix that means 'above and beyond,' " he says. "So no matter what the word is, you can get its meaning if you take it apart."
- 20 "Okay, Dad. I get it. So did I tell you we're having a book sale for our next fundraiser?"
- 21 "What else are you doing in English?" he asks. "Reading any novels?"
- 22 I sigh, bored, but he doesn't get the hint. He just waits for my answer. "Yes," I finally say. "I don't remember the title, but it's got a rabbit on the cover."
- 23 "Is it *Watership Down*? It's got to be *Watership Down*."
- 24 "Yes, that's it. But I left it in my locker. I guess I can't do my homework."
- 25 "Nonsense. I've got a copy somewhere. Let me look."
- 26 He leaves the table to scan the bookshelves, and all of the sudden, I *care* about the tough beef, the mushy potatoes, and the cold beans. Why should I eat when my own father has abandoned his food? Nothing's more important than his books and vocabulary words. He might say I matter, but when he goes on a scavenger hunt for a book, I realize that I really don't.
- 27 I take my plate to the kitchen, grab my half-finished soda, and head to my room. When I walk past him, he's kneeling to search the lower shelves. He's got a paper towel and wipes it lovingly over the titles as if polishing a sports car. He doesn't hear my angry, stomping footsteps. I catch the last part of his sentence.

¹ *cascarones*—hollow eggs filled with confetti or toys

- 28 “. . . a classic epic journey,” he says as if he were in class with a bunch of students. I can’t stand it. I just can’t stand it. I’d rather have Vanessa’s crazy mom.
- 29 Later, just as I write *I love Luís* for the three-hundredth time, my dad peeks through my bedroom door.
- 30 “Found my copy of *Watership Down*,” he says, handing me a paperback whose spine’s been taped a dozen times. “How far do you have to read tonight?”
- 31 “The first four chapters,” I say.
- 32 “That’s a lot. You better get busy.”
- 33 “Sure, Dad. I’ll start reading right away.”
- 34 But I don’t. As soon as he leaves, I put the book on my nightstand and use it as a coaster. The condensation from my soda makes a big, wet circle on the cover.

From CONFETTI GIRL by Diana López. Copyright © 2009 by Diana López. By permission of Little, Brown, and Company.

1. Part A

What is the meaning of the word **sarcasm** as it is used in paragraph 18 of the passage from *Confetti Girl*?

- A. a remark indicating mockery and annoyance
- B. a response that is meant to be taken literally
- C. an answer that indicates confusion or skepticism
- D. an observation that is silly and childish

Part B

Which quotation from the passage helps clarify the meaning of **sarcasm**?

- A. ““Super . . . super . . . super something. Can’t remember.”” (paragraph 15)
- B. ““It could have been *super-duper* or *super-loop* for all I care.”” (paragraph 17)
- C. ““So did I tell you we’re having a book sale for our next fundraiser?”” (paragraph 20)
- D. ““Yes, that’s it. But I left it in my locker. I guess I can’t do my homework.”” (paragraph 24)

2. Part A

What attitude does the narrator of *Confetti Girl* reveal when she uses the book as a coaster in paragraph 34?

- A. worry about being able to finish her schoolwork
- B. dishonesty in lying to her father about her homework
- C. carelessness when it comes to doing household chores
- D. resentment of her father's efforts to impose his interests on her

Part B

Which quotation from the passage **best** shows additional evidence of the attitude in Part A?

- A. "Dad helps, but sometimes he makes a big mess." (paragraph 2)
- B. "And I don't want to talk to him because I'm still mad about the volleyball game" (paragraph 3)
- C. "Nothing's more important than his books and vocabulary words. He might say I matter, but when he goes on a scavenger hunt for a book, I realize that I really don't." (paragraph 26)
- D. "Later, just as I write *I love Luís* for the three-hundredth time, my dad peeks through my bedroom door." (paragraph 29)

Read the passage from the novel *Tortilla Sun*. Then answer questions 3 and 4.

from *Tortilla Sun*

by Jennifer Cervantes

- 1 *Clang cla-clang, clang clang.* The next morning, I found Mom in the kitchen with a chisel and hammer, chipping away at the kitchen counter. Little flecks of white flew through the air like ceramic snow, landing softly on her olive-colored cheeks.
- 2 I ducked as a piece of tile flew at me. “Hey!”
- 3 She turned toward me with a look of surprise. “Morning, Izzy. I didn’t see you standing there.”
- 4 “Wha . . . what are you doing?” I asked.
- 5 She stepped back and surveyed the half-demolished counter the way someone stands back to study a newly hung photograph. Wiping her cheek with the back of her hand she said, “There was this”—she searched the mess on the floor—“this one broken tile poking out and I thought I should fix it and . . .”
- 6 I pushed past her to get the broom but she grabbed me by the elbow. A feeling of nervousness swelled inside me.
- 7 “Izzy, wait. I have something to tell you.”
- 8 There it was. My heart buckled in my chest. Something was wrong.
- 9 Mom leaned back against the counter and sucked in a great gulp of air. “It’s strange actually. I wasn’t expecting it, but then at the last minute the funding came through.” She folded her arms across her waist. “I’m going to Costa Rica to finish my research.”
- 10 Her words buzzed around me like a swarm of confused bees. “When? For how long?”
- 11 “I’ll be gone for most of the summer. I leave Tuesday.”
- 12 Mom wouldn’t leave me. We’d go together. Right? “But that’s only three days away.” I stepped away from Mom and the shards of tile.
- 13 “I don’t have a choice.”
- 14 “But what am I supposed to do? That’s three whole months.”
- 15 “Two. I’ll be home at the end of July. And after this I can finally graduate. Our lives will change then.” She reached over and stroked my hair. “For the better.”

GO ON ►

- 16 I rolled those three words around in my mind: *for the better*.
- 17 Suddenly last night’s phone call made perfect sense. I inched closer and pushed at the broken tile with my toes.
- 18 “Are you sending me to Nana’s?” I asked. “In New Mexico?”
- 19 A flash of surprise crossed Mom’s face. Like she knew I had heard her phone conversation. “She’s so excited to have you and . . .”
- 20 “What happened to all your talk about you guys not seeing eye to eye?” I asked.
- 21 “It’s not that we don’t see eye to eye. We just don’t see the world the same way.”
- 22 “Why can’t I go with you?” I said.
- 23 “Izzy . . .”
- 24 “New Mexico is worlds away from California. And what am I going to do for two whole months with someone I haven’t seen since I was six? That was half my life ago. She’s a stranger!” I felt a sudden urge to bolt for the front door and run.
- 25 Mom rolled her eyes. “Oh, Izzy. She’s hardly a stranger. She’s family. I already have your ticket. You leave Monday.” Mom opened the refrigerator and took out a diet soda, pressing the cold can against her face before opening it.
- 26 I stared at the mess on the floor. “Why can’t I stay here? Alone.” My voice quivered.
- 27 Mom took a swig of her soda, then closed her eyes and took a deep breath. When she opened them, she spoke slowly and deliberately.
- 28 “You’re going to New Mexico and that’s final.”
- 29 I swallowed hard and tried not to cry. “Why do you always get to decide everything? We just unpacked and I—I had plans.”
- 30 She raised her eyebrows, surprised. “Plans?”
- 31 Mom was always bugging me to make friends, which I didn’t see the point of, considering we moved every few months. And we moved for all sorts of reasons: closer to the university for her, better school for me, quieter, prettier, bigger, smaller.
- 32 “I was going to try and find some girls my age here in the complex so I wouldn’t have to be the new kid in school *again*,” I said, trying to sound believable.
- 33 “Honey, you can make friends at your new school in the fall. Besides, this is a wonderful opportunity for you.”

- 34 “Opportunity? For me? Or for you?”
- 35 I stormed off to my room and threw myself onto my bed. I ached inside. Like the feeling you get watching a lost balloon float far into the sky until it becomes an invisible nothing.
- 36 I reached for a story card and scribbled:
- 37 ***Gypsy was sent to prison for stealing the magic ball. And when she was tossed into the dungeon below the castle she found the word “opportunity” written across the stone wall.***
- 38 Staring at the card, I wondered what should happen next. Maybe a daring escape or a sorceress could rescue her. When nothing came to me, I scratched out the word *opportunity* until it was a big blob of blue ink and tossed the card on the floor.
- 39 I heard Mom’s footsteps coming toward my closed bedroom door. I held my breath, hoping she wouldn’t knock.
- 40 *Tap. Tap.*
- 41 Silence.
- 42 “Izzy?” she spoke quietly.
- 43 My hands wandered beneath my pillow and gripped the baseball I had hidden there. I squeezed my eyes closed and whispered, “I wish I didn’t have to go. I wish I didn’t have to go.”
- 44 “I’ve brought your suitcase.” She stood outside my door for what seemed like forever. I pictured her on the other side, arms crossed, head down.
- 45 “I think you’re going to like the village.” Her voice became a little muffled now, like her mouth was pressed right up against the door. “It’s strange and beautiful at the same time and a perfect place to explore. You just might be surprised what you find there.” She paused for a moment then continued. “Would you please talk to me?”
- 46 I burrowed my head under the pillow with the baseball. A tiny piece of me felt guilty for stealing it, but it belonged to my dad and that made it special. That made it a part of me.
- 47 “I’ll just leave the suitcase here for you,” she said. Her bare feet slapped against the tile and carried her away.

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GO ON ►

3. Part A

How do the phrases **stormed off**, **float far**, and **invisible nothing** in paragraph 35 contribute to the tone of the passage?

- A. They call attention to the narrator’s feelings of guilt and disappointment.
- B. They emphasize the narrator’s growing sense of hopelessness.
- C. They reflect the narrator’s escape into comforting daydreams.
- D. They highlight the narrator’s strong sense of independence.

Part B

Selecting from paragraphs 32–34 and 36–39, circle the paragraph that **most** directly reinforces the tone created in paragraph 35.

- 32 “I was going to try and find some girls my age here in the complex so I wouldn’t have to be the new kid in school *again*,” I said, trying to sound believable.
- 33 “Honey, you can make friends at your new school in the fall. Besides, this is a wonderful opportunity for you.”
- 34 “Opportunity? For me? Or for you?”
- 36 I reached for a story card and scribbled:
- 37 ***Gypsy was sent to prison for stealing the magic ball. And when she was tossed into the dungeon below the castle she found the word “opportunity” written across the stone wall.***
- 38 Staring at the card, I wondered what should happen next. Maybe a daring escape or a sorceress could rescue her. When nothing came to me, I scratched out the word *opportunity* until it was a big blob of blue ink and tossed the card on the floor.
- 39 I heard Mom’s footsteps coming toward my closed bedroom door. I held my breath, hoping she wouldn’t knock.

4. Part A

Which statement provides an objective summary of the passage?

- A. A mother chooses to neglect her daughter's interests in favor of completing her degree. She informs her daughter of this decision, and the daughter rightly points out the mother's selfishness.
- B. A mother decides it would be best for her daughter if they both moved to another country. The daughter complains that this will disrupt her life, but the mother holds firm to her decision.
- C. A girl learns that she and her mother are moving in with their grandmother. She believes her mother is trying to take the easy way out. In response, she states that her father is a better parent.
- D. A girl finds out her mother is going to leave her for the summer. She believes her mother is being selfish and neglecting her. In response, she becomes negative and withdrawn.

GO ON ►

Part B

Circle the **three** details from the passage that are **most** relevant to providing an objective summary of the passage. Then show the correct order of those details by numbering them 1, 2 and 3.

Clang cla-clang, clang clang. The next morning, I found Mom in the kitchen with a chisel and hammer, chipping away at the kitchen counter. Little flecks of white flew through the air like ceramic snow, landing softly on her olive-colored cheeks. (paragraph 1)

She stepped back and surveyed the half-demolished counter the way someone stands back to study a newly hung photograph. Wiping her cheek with the back of her hand she said, “There was this”—she searched the mess on the floor—“this one broken tile poking out and I thought I should fix it and . . .” (paragraph 5)

Mom leaned back against the counter and sucked in a great gulp of air. “It’s strange actually. I wasn’t expecting it, but then at the last minute the funding came through.” She folded her arms across her waist. “I’m going to Costa Rica to finish my research.” (paragraph 9)

Suddenly last night’s phone call made perfect sense. I inched closer and pushed at the broken tile with my toes. (paragraph 17)

“You’re going to New Mexico and that’s final.” (paragraph 28)

“Opportunity? For me? Or for you?” (paragraph 34)

“I think you’re going to like the village.” Her voice became a little muffled now, like her mouth was pressed right up against the door. “It’s strange and beautiful at the same time and a perfect place to explore. You just might be surprised what you find there.” She paused for a moment then continued. “Would you please talk to me?” (paragraph 45)

Refer to the passage from *Confetti Girl* and the passage from *Tortilla Sun*. Then answer questions 5 through 7.

5. Part A

The passage from *Confetti Girl* begins with the narrator’s memories of her mother (paragraph 1). The passage from *Tortilla Sun* ends with Izzy’s thoughts about the baseball that belonged to her father (paragraph 46). How do these paragraphs contribute to an understanding of both narrators?

- A. The paragraphs reveal that the narrators have little reason to feel upset about their present situations.
- B. The paragraphs suggest the efforts the narrators will go to so that they may please their parents.
- C. The paragraphs emphasize the fact that the narrators may not be reporting events truthfully.
- D. The paragraphs highlight the narrators’ strong desire to regain a sense of closeness.

Part B

What additional similarity between the narrators builds on the same idea?

- A. They both have trouble connecting with their remaining parent.
- B. They both have an active and rich imaginary life.
- C. They both feel as if there is no point in making friends.
- D. They both have parents who value education above all else.

6. Part A

In both passages, what causes the conflict between the narrator and her parent?

- A. The narrator does something to disappoint her parent.
- B. The narrator misunderstands her parent's intentions.
- C. The parent acts in a way that neglects the narrator's interests.
- D. The parent makes a mess that the narrator will have to clean up.

Part B

Which paragraphs from the two passages **best** support the answer to Part A?

- A. paragraph 3, *Confetti Girl*; paragraph 1, *Tortilla Sun*
- B. paragraph 12, *Confetti Girl*; paragraph 5, *Tortilla Sun*
- C. paragraph 19, *Confetti Girl*; paragraph 6, *Tortilla Sun*
- D. paragraph 26, *Confetti Girl*; paragraph 9, *Tortilla Sun*

7. In the passages from *Confetti Girl* and *Tortilla Sun*, the narrators have points of view different from those of their parents. Write an essay analyzing how these differences in points of view create tension in both stories. Remember to use details from both texts to support your ideas.

[illegible]

GO ON ►

A large rectangular box containing 20 horizontal lines for writing.

GO ON ►

This image shows a single page of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There is a vertical margin line on the left side, creating a narrow left margin. The paper appears to be from a notebook or a standard ruled sheet of paper.

GO ON ►

A large rectangular box containing 20 horizontal lines for writing.

GO ON ►

Read the passage from “Emerald Ash Borer.” Then answer questions 8 through 11.

from “Emerald Ash Borer”

by Department of Energy and Environmental Protection

- 1 The emerald ash borer is a small, green beetle that belongs to a large family of beetles known as the buprestids, or metallic wood boring beetles. The description is apt, as many of the adult buprestids are indeed glossy, appearing as if their wing covers are made of polished metal. The emerald ash borer, with its green, iridescent wing covers, fits right in. Adult EABs are between 0.3 to 0.55 inches in length—small by most standards but large compared to other buprestids—and relatively slender.
- 2 During its life cycle, EAB undergoes a complete metamorphosis. It starts as an egg, becomes a larva (alternatively called a grub), and then changes to become a pupa and then an adult. The life cycle of an EAB takes either 1 or 2 years to complete. Adults begin emerging from within ash trees around the middle of June, with emergence continuing for about 5 weeks. The female starts laying her eggs on the bark of ash trees about 2 weeks after emergence. After 7 to 10 days, the eggs hatch and the larvae move into the bark, to begin feeding on the phloem (inner bark) and cambium of the tree. Throughout each of its successive instars (larval growth stages), the larva continues to feed within this same part of the tree. The larval stage may last for nearly two years. Before becoming an adult, the insect overwinters as a pre-pupal larva. It then pupates in the spring and emerges as an adult during the summer.
- 3 EAB feeds strictly on ash trees. The larvae feed on the phloem and cambium, while the adults feed on leaves. In Connecticut, there are three species of ash trees—the white ash (*Fraxinus americana*), the green or red ash (*F. pennsylvanica*) and the black ash (*F. nigra*). Despite its common name, mountain ash (*Sorbus* spp.) is not a true ash and does not attract the EAB.
- 4 Two other buprestids are well-known to those in Connecticut who are concerned about trees. The bronze birch borer is a pest of ornamental birch trees. The two-lined chestnut borer often attacks stressed oak trees, including oaks in the forest.

GO ON ►

Why is EAB a Problem?

- 5 EAB is an insect that is not native to North America. It was first found in 2002 in the vicinity of Detroit, MI, and Windsor, ON. It had arrived sometime within the several years previous, presumably on woody packaging materials. It is now known to be found in 12 states. It is considered to be established in several of the upper Midwest states where it was first found. Movement of ash, in particular ash nursery stock and ash wood in the form of firewood, logs and wood packaging materials, has been cited as a likely means by which EAB has been assisted in its spread. More recently, strict regulations have been initiated to prevent the movement of these materials from infested areas.

from Emerald Ash Borer by Department of Energy and Environmental Protection—Public Domain

8. Part A

How does the author organize the information about the emerald ash borer?

- A. by providing general facts followed by a statement of a problem
- B. by defining the problem in scientific terms followed by an argument for proposed action
- C. by presenting a problem followed by a suggested solution
- D. by listing facts in order of importance followed by causes of a problem

Part B

How does paragraph 3 contribute to the organizational pattern of the passage?

- A. by showing why some facts about EABs are of greater significance than others
- B. by explaining what course of action should be taken to prevent borer infestations
- C. by providing the scientific names of various species of borer insects
- D. by contrasting the food sources of the mature and immature EABs

9. Part A

What is one reason why the author includes the explanation about the EAB in paragraph 5?

- A. to help the reader understand the types of damage the EAB causes
- B. to help the reader understand why the EAB has become a concern
- C. to help the reader understand how the EAB exists in ash trees
- D. to help the reader understand where the EAB will mostly likely travel next

Part B

Which detail from paragraph 5 **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “. . . not native to North America.”
- B. “. . . known to be found in 12 states.”
- C. “. . . in particular ash nursery stock and ash wood”
- D. “. . . movement of these materials from infested areas.”

10. Part A

What is the meaning of **established** as it is used in paragraph 5 of the passage?

- A. in a strong position permitting growth
- B. proven beyond a doubt
- C. well known and respected
- D. accepted as a rule or law

Part B

Which phrase from paragraph 5 helps the reader understand the meaning of **established**?

- A. “. . . not native”
- B. “. . . first found”
- C. “. . . several years previous”
- D. “. . . found in 12 states.”

11. Part A

Based on the information in the passage, what is one conclusion that can be drawn about the emerald ash borer?

- A. The habits of the emerald ash borer are harmful to ash trees.
- B. The emerald ash borer is the most destructive of the buprestids in North America.
- C. The buprestids, including the emerald ash borer, cause problems for Connecticut homeowners.
- D. Additional laws are needed in North America to protect the ash trees from the emerald ash borer.

Part B

Which evidence from the passage supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “The larvae feed on the phloem and cambium, while the adults feed on leaves.” (paragraph 3)
- B. “Two other buprestids are well-known to those in Connecticut” (paragraph 4)
- C. “The two-lined chestnut borer often attacks stressed oak trees” (paragraph 4)
- D. “More recently, strict regulations have been initiated to prevent the movement of these materials from infested areas.” (paragraph 5)



Session 2

Research Simulation Task

Directions:

Today you will take Session 2 of the Grade 8 English Language Arts Practice Test.

Read each passage and question. Then follow the directions to answer each question. Mark your answers by **circling** the correct choices in your test booklet. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

One of the questions will ask you to write a response. Write your response in the space provided in your test booklet.

If you do not know the answer to a question, you may go on to the next question. If you finish early, you may review your answers and any questions you did not answer in this session **ONLY**. Do not go past the stop sign.

GO ON ►

Today you will research the topic of sound and the invention of the phonograph. You will read the article “The Incredible Talking Machine.” Then you will read a passage from the article “History of the Cylinder Phonograph” and the article “Psst . . . Hey, You.” As you review these sources, you will gather information and answer questions about sound and the invention of the phonograph so you can write an essay.

Read the article “The Incredible Talking Machine.” Then answer questions 12 through 14.

The Incredible Talking Machine

by Randall Stross

- 1 In the end, they named it the phonograph. But it might have been called the omphlegraph, meaning “voice writer.” Or the antiphone (back talker). Or the didasko phone (portable teacher). These are some of the names someone wrote in a logbook in Thomas Edison’s laboratory in 1877, after Edison and his assistants invented the first rudimentary machine for recording and playing back sounds. From the first, they thought it would be used to reproduce the human voice, but they had no clear idea of its exact purpose.
- 2 Edison once said, “Anything that won’t sell, I don’t want to invent.” But all his life, he was a better inventor than salesman. The phonograph, his first invention to make him world-famous, is a perfect example. It was the product of a well-prepared but wandering mind.
- 3 It was also the outcome of an amazing burst of inventiveness. One evening in July 1877, while relaxing with his assistants after their regular midnight dinner, Edison had an idea. They were working with ways to use paper strips to make a record of telegraph messages. Why not adapt those to record the vibrations of the diaphragm in a telephone mouthpiece? Thinking out loud, Edison suggested attaching a needle to the back of the diaphragm and mounting it above rollers for the paper strips. Speaking into the mouthpiece would cause the diaphragm to move, which in turn would cause the needle to inscribe squiggled indentations into the strips. If the paper were then pulled through the rollers again with the needle resting in the groove, the indentations would move the attached diaphragm, which should reproduce the original sound.
- 4 Edison’s assistants set to work. Within the hour, they had a working device they tried out by reciting “Mary had a little lamb” into the telephone. In the first trial, all that could be heard from the playback was “ary ad ell am.” But that was encouraging. The staff went on working through the night, fiddling with the gizmo—and thus occurred the first midnight recording session.

GO ON ►

- 5 Edison and his crew later replaced the paper and rollers with tinfoil, which was wrapped around a cylinder attached to a crank. But Edison did not regard the machine as commercially promising. At best, he thought, it might be an office machine allowing businessmen to dictate letters.
- 6 When word of the invention spread, however, the outside world saw greater possibilities. The dead could speak to us, eternally! Collectors could keep what the *New York Times* called a “well-stocked oratorical cellar.” But the primitive phonograph that Edison demonstrated for the editors of *Scientific American* that December remained exceedingly limited. It could clearly introduce itself—“How do you do? How do you like the phonograph?”—but that exhausted its recording capacity.
- 7 Still, the editors were excited enough to publish an admiring bulletin about the device—a first shot that set off an avalanche of publicity. A reporter wrote him, “I want to know you right bad,” and everyone else did too. Investors enlisted him in a new venture, the Edison Speaking Phonograph Co. But he soon lost interest in making the phonograph a salable product. The company introduced a toy model that functioned badly and a second, more expensive one that was used by show-business entrepreneurs who rented concert halls to demonstrate the wondrous machine to paying audiences. It broke down frequently and required a trained technician’s constant attention.
- 8 Ten years elapsed before Edison returned to the phonograph, only after a competitor developed a wax-coated cylinder that could be removed without ruining the recording, something impossible to do with Edison’s delicate tinfoil. To him, the idea that his most cherished invention faced competition was unendurable. He set to work on what he would call the Perfected Phonograph. When he introduced it to the market, however, in 1889, it was anything but perfect as the dictation device he still thought it to be. But it played music beautifully. Edison’s backers tried to persuade him that the phonograph could be marketed for entertainment purposes, but he could not let go of his conviction that it was destined for the office.
- 9 Competitors leaped further ahead, developing a new recording medium, the disc, and rushing to sign musical artists to recording contracts. Eventually, Edison capitulated and entered the recorded-music business too—a business he was poorly suited to as a man who disapproved of most genres of popular music. He dismissed “miserable dance and ragtime selections” and described jazz as something for “the nuts.” Another competitor soon emerged, the Victor Talking Machine Co. and its Victrola. And while Victor built a stable of notable musical artists, Edison remained unwilling to pay royalty advances necessary to recruit stars.

- 10 In the 1920s, Edison’s phonograph faced a new challenge, commercial radio. The other phonograph companies introduced radios but Edison refused, wanting nothing to do with the medium’s inferior sound quality. Prodded by his sons, he grudgingly relented, but the move came too late—in the midst of the stock-market crash of 1929. Within a year, his radio company ceased production. Edison died a year later. The music industry he had set in motion lived on, evolving into stereo, iPods and streaming music. He had made it all possible, without ever quite grasping how to make the most of it for himself.

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12. Part A

Read the sentence from paragraph 1.

These are some of the names someone wrote in a logbook in Thomas Edison's laboratory in 1877, after Edison and his assistants invented the first rudimentary machine for recording and playing back sounds.

What is the meaning of the word **rudimentary** as it is used in the sentence?

- A. basic
- B. mobile
- C. practical
- D. original

Part B

Which sentence from the article supports the answer to Part A?

- A. "The phonograph, his first invention to make him world-famous, is a perfect example." (paragraph 2)
- B. "It was also the outcome of an amazing burst of inventiveness." (paragraph 3)
- C. "When word of the invention spread, however, the outside world saw greater possibilities." (paragraph 6)
- D. "But the primitive phonograph that Edison demonstrated for the editors of *Scientific American* that December remained exceedingly limited." (paragraph 6)

13. Part A

Which statement describes the central idea of “The Incredible Talking Machine”?

- A. Edison was dependent on his assistants and backers to be successful.
- B. Edison was never able to comprehend the full potential of his invention.
- C. Edison was more gifted at promoting his inventions than designing them.
- D. Edison was so impressed with his own invention that he ignored constructive criticism.

Part B

Circle **two** pieces of evidence from the article that **best** support the answer to Part A.

- A. “From the first, they thought it would be used to reproduce the human voice, but they had no clear idea of its exact purpose.” (paragraph 1)
- B. “The staff went on working through the night, fiddling with the gizmo—and thus occurred the first midnight recording session.” (paragraph 4)
- C. “At best, he thought, it might be an office machine allowing businessmen to dictate letters.” (paragraph 5)
- D. “Still, the editors were excited enough to publish an admiring bulletin about the device—a first shot that set off an avalanche of publicity.” (paragraph 7)
- E. “To him, the idea that his most cherished invention faced competition was unendurable.” (paragraph 8)
- F. “He dismissed ‘miserable dance and ragtime selections’ and described jazz as something for ‘the nuts.’” (paragraph 9)

14. Part A

How does the author of “The Incredible Talking Machine” **mainly** present information throughout the article?

- A. by presenting a cause and its effects
- B. by describing events in sequential order
- C. by explaining a problem and its solution
- D. by comparing and contrasting events

Part B

Which sentence from the article **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “If the paper were then pulled through the rollers again with the needle resting in the groove, the indentations would move the attached diaphragm . . .” (paragraph 3)
- B. “It broke down frequently and required a trained technician’s constant attention.” (paragraph 7)
- C. “Ten years elapsed before Edison returned to the phonograph, only after a competitor developed a wax-coated cylinder that could be removed without ruining the recording . . .” (paragraph 8)
- D. “The other phonograph companies introduced radios but Edison refused, wanting nothing to do with the medium’s inferior sound quality.” (paragraph 10)

Read the passage from “History of the Cylinder Phonograph.” Then answer questions 15 and 16.

from “History of the Cylinder Phonograph”

- 1 The phonograph was developed as a result of Thomas Edison’s work on two other inventions, the telegraph and the telephone. In 1877, Edison was working on a machine that would transcribe telegraphic messages through indentations on paper tape, which could later be sent over the telegraph repeatedly. This development led Edison to speculate that a telephone message could also be recorded in a similar fashion. He experimented with a diaphragm which had an embossing point and was held against rapidly moving paraffin paper. The speaking vibrations made indentations in the paper. Edison later changed the paper to a metal cylinder with tin foil wrapped around it. The machine had two diaphragm-and-needle units, one for recording, and one for playback. When one would speak into a mouthpiece, the sound vibrations would be indented onto the cylinder by the recording needle in a vertical (or hill and dale) groove pattern. Edison gave a sketch of the machine to his mechanic, John Kruesi, to build, which Kruesi supposedly did within 30 hours. Edison immediately tested the machine by speaking the nursery rhyme into the mouthpiece, “Mary had a little lamb.” To his amazement, the machine played his words back to him.
- 2 Although it was later stated that the date for this event was on August 12, 1877, some historians believe that it probably happened several months later, since Edison did not file for a patent until December 24, 1877. Also, the diary of one of Edison’s aides, Charles Batchelor, seems to confirm that the phonograph was not constructed until December 4, and finished two days later. The patent on the phonograph was issued on February 19, 1878. The invention was highly original. The only other recorded evidence of such an invention was in a paper by French scientist Charles Cros, written on April 18, 1877. There were some differences, however, between the two men’s ideas, and Cros’s work remained only a theory, since he did not produce a working model of it.
- 3 Edison took his new invention to the offices of *Scientific American* in New York City and showed it to staff there. As the December 22, 1877, issue reported, “Mr. Thomas A. Edison recently came into this office, placed a little machine on our desk, turned a crank, and the machine inquired as to our health, asked how we liked the phonograph, informed us that it was very well, and bid us a cordial good night.” Interest was great, and the invention was reported in several New York newspapers, and later in other American newspapers and magazines.
- 4 The Edison Speaking Phonograph Company was established on January 24, 1878, to exploit the new machine by exhibiting it. Edison received \$10,000 for the manufacturing and sales rights and 20% of the profits. As a novelty, the machine was an instant success, but was difficult to operate except by experts, and the tin foil would last for only a few playings.

GO ON ►

- 5 Ever practical and visionary, Edison offered the following possible future uses for the phonograph in the *North American Review* in June 1878:
1. Letter writing and all kinds of dictation without the aid of a stenographer.
 2. Phonographic books, which will speak to blind people without effort on their part.
 3. The teaching of elocution.
 4. Reproduction of music.
 5. The “Family Record”—a registry of sayings, reminiscences, etc., by members of a family in their own voices, and of the last words of dying persons.
 6. Music-boxes and toys.
 7. Clocks that should announce in articulate speech the time for going home, going to meals, etc.
 8. The preservation of languages by exact reproduction of the manner of pronouncing.
 9. Educational purposes; such as preserving the explanations made by a teacher, so that the pupil can refer to them at any moment, and spelling or other lessons placed upon the phonograph for convenience in committing to memory.
 10. Connection with the telephone, so as to make that instrument an auxiliary in the transmission of permanent and invaluable records, instead of being the recipient of momentary and fleeting communication.
- 6 Eventually, the novelty of the invention wore off for the public, and Edison did no further work on the phonograph for a while, concentrating instead on inventing the incandescent light bulb.

“The History of the Edison Cylinder Phonograph”—Public Domain/The Library of Congress

15. Part A

In paragraph 4, what is the meaning of the word **exploit**?

- A. research
- B. promote
- C. improve
- D. defend

Part B

What phrase from paragraph 4 supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “. . . machine was an instant success”
- B. “. . . difficult to operate”
- C. “. . . except by experts”
- D. “. . . last for only a few playings.”

16. Part A

Which part of the invention process was **most likely** the key step for securing the patent?

- A. testing the machine
- B. improving the machine's parts
- C. constructing the original machine
- D. demonstrating the machine to the public

Part B

Which statement from the passage supports the answer to Part A?

- A. "Edison later changed the paper to a metal cylinder with tin foil wrapped around it." (paragraph 1)
- B. "To his amazement, the machine played his words back to him." (paragraph 1)
- C. ". . . and Cros's work remained only a theory, since he did not produce a working model of it." (paragraph 2)
- D. "Interest was great, and the invention was reported in several New York newspapers . . ." (paragraph 3)

Read the article “Psst . . . Hey, You.” Then answer questions 17 and 18.

Psst . . . Hey, You

by Mark Fischetti

- 1 You are walking down a quiet grocery store aisle when suddenly a voice says: “Thirsty? Buy me.” You stop in front of the soda display, but no one is next to you, and shoppers a few feet away do not seem to hear a thing.
- 2 At that moment, you are standing in a cylinder of sound. Whereas a loudspeaker broadcasts sound in all directions, the way a lightbulb radiates light, a directional speaker shines a beam of waves akin to a spotlight. The beam consists of ultrasound waves, which humans cannot hear, but which can emit audible tones as they interact with air. By describing these interactions mathematically, engineers can coax a beam to exude voice, music or any other sound.
- 3 Military and sonar researchers tried to harness the phenomenon as far back as the 1960s but only managed to generate highly distorted audible signals. In 1998 Joseph Pompei, then at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, published algorithms that cut the distortion to only a few percent. He then designed an amplifier, electronics, and speakers to produce ultrasound “that is clean enough to generate clean audio,” Pompei says. He trademarked the technology Audio Spotlight and started Holosonics, Inc., in Watertown, MA, in 1999. Rival inventor Woody Norris markets a competing product called HyperSonic Sound from his American Technology Corporation in San Diego.
- 4 Pompei’s speakers are installed in company lobbies, and above exhibits at the Boston Museum of Fine Arts and Walt Disney World’s Epcot Center, among other locations. Narrations inform visitors standing in front of artifacts or video screens without filling the rooms with noise. Department stores have tried the arrangement for retail displays, and automakers are experimenting with them so passengers can hear only their own music or movies. A speaker above a recliner in the living room would allow Dad to hear the television while other family members read on the couch in peace.
- 5 Detractors say that in certain situations headphones can provide similar benefits, and note random problems, such as unwanted reflections off a car seat. But the primary obstacle to wider deployment is cost: systems can run from \$600 to \$1,000 or more. If the price drops, consumers are more likely to consider buying the gear . . . or encounter it while shopping.

GO ON ►

DID YOU KNOW . . .

- **BOUNCED:** Ultrasound waves remain in a tight column where they reflect off a hard, smooth surface. Police teams could bounce a beam off a building at the end of an alley or off a distant window inside a warehouse to flush out suspects, who would run away from the sound—and right into the officers’ waiting arms.
- **BATS NOT DOGS:** Certain animals can detect the ultrasound noise behind audible directed sound. The ultrasound speakers emit frequencies from 40,000 to 80,000 cycles a second, or hertz (Hz). Humans typically hear frequencies between 20 and 20,000 Hz. Dogs can hear up to 40,000 Hz or so, mice up to 90,000, and bats, porpoises, and beluga whales up to 100,000 Hz or higher.
- **BONUS:** Middle ear bones limit human hearing to below 20,000 Hz. But researchers have applied ultrasound up to 200,000 Hz to the skulls of volunteers, some of whom report “hearing” sounds; the skull may be distorting vibrations that reach the cochlea.

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17. Part A

In paragraph 2, what does the word **exude** mean?

- A. to project
- B. to disguise
- C. to assist
- D. to calculate

Part B

Which statement from paragraph 2 supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “. . . standing in a cylinder of sound”
- B. “. . . which humans cannot hear”
- C. “. . . emit audible tones as they interact with air”
- D. “. . . describing these interactions mathematically”

18. Part A

In paragraph 2, how does the author help the reader understand how ultrasound works?

- A. by describing the features of new technology
- B. by using familiar concepts to explain new technology
- C. by explaining how researchers discovered new technology
- D. by providing additional resources about the new technology

Part B

Which sentence from paragraph 2 **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “At that moment, you are standing in a cylinder of sound.”
- B. “Whereas a loudspeaker broadcasts sound in all directions, the way a lightbulb radiates light, a directional speaker shines a beam of waves akin to a spotlight.”
- C. “The beam consists of ultrasound waves, which humans cannot hear, but which can emit audible tones as they interact with air.”
- D. “By describing these interactions mathematically, engineers can coax a beam to exude voice, music or any other sound.”

Refer to the article “The Incredible Talking Machine,” the passage from “History of the Cylinder Phonograph,” and the article “Psst . . . Hey, You.” Then answer questions 19 and 20.

19. Part A

What is the central idea of “Psst . . . Hey, You” that is supported by the other articles?

- A. Sound technology continues to evolve.
- B. Modern inventors must compete for recognition.
- C. Directional speakers are useful in commercial business.
- D. Advances in technology are prohibitively expensive.

Part B

Which sentence from the article **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “He then designed an amplifier, electronics, and speakers to produce ultrasound ‘that is clean enough to generate clean audio,’ Pompei says.” (paragraph 3)
- B. “Rival inventor Woody Norris markets a competing product called HyperSonic Sound from his American Technology Corporation in San Diego.” (paragraph 3)
- C. “Pompei’s speakers are installed in company lobbies, and above exhibits at the Boston Museum of Fine Arts and Walt Disney World’s Epcot Center, among other locations.” (paragraph 4)
- D. “But the primary obstacle to wider deployment is cost: systems can run from \$600 to \$1,000 or more.” (paragraph 5)

GO ON ►

- 20.** You have now read **two** articles about the beginning of sound technology and **one** article about modern technology. Write an essay explaining how the process of refining and marketing the phonograph is similar to the development of the Audio Spotlight in “Psst . . . Hey, You.” Be sure to use details from all **three** articles to support your answer.

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Session 3

Narrative Writing Task and Reading Passages

Directions:

Today you will take Session 3 of the Grade 8 English Language Arts Practice Test.

Read each passage and question. Then follow the directions to answer each question. Mark your answers by **circling** the correct choices in your test booklet. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

Some of the questions will ask you to write a response. Write your response in the space provided in your test booklet.

If you do not know the answer to a question, you may go on to the next question. If you finish early, you may review your answers and any questions you did not answer in this session **ONLY**. Do not go past the stop sign.

GO ON ►

Today you will read the folktale “The Fox and the Horse.” As you read and answer the questions, pay close attention to characters and events to prepare to write a narrative story.

Read the folktale “The Fox and the Horse.” Then answer questions 21 through 25.

The Fox and the Horse

- 1 A peasant once had a faithful horse, but it had grown old and could no longer do its work. Its master begrudged it food, and said: “I can’t use you anymore, but I still feel kindly towards you, and if you show yourself strong enough to bring me a lion I will keep you to the end of your days. But away with you now, out of my stable”; and he drove it out into the open country.
- 2 The poor horse was very sad, and went into the forest to get a little shelter from the wind and weather. There he met a fox, who said: “Why do you hang your head, and wander about in this solitary fashion?”
- 3 “Alas!” answered the horse. “Avarice and honesty cannot live together. My master has forgotten all the service I have done him for these many years, and because I can no longer plough he will no longer feed me, and he has driven me away.”
- 4 “Without any consideration?” asked the fox.
- 5 “Only the poor consolation of telling me that if I was strong enough to bring him a lion he would keep me, but he knows well enough that the task is beyond me.”
- 6 The fox said, “But I will help you. Just you lie down here, and stretch your legs out as if you were dead.” The horse did as he was told, and the fox went to the lion’s den, not far off, and said: “There is a dead horse out there. Come along with me, and you will have a rare meal.” The lion went with him, and when they got up to the horse, the fox said, “You can’t eat it in comfort here. I’ll tell you what. I will tie it to you, and you can drag it away to your den and enjoy it at your leisure.”
- 7 The plan pleased the lion, and he stood quite still, close to the horse, so that the fox should fasten them together. But the fox tied the lion’s legs together with the horse’s tail and twisted and knotted it so that it would be quite impossible for it to come undone.
- 8 When he had finished his work he patted the horse on the shoulder and said: “Pull, old grey! Pull!”

GO ON ►

- 9 Then the horse sprang up and dragged the lion away behind him. The lion in his rage roared so that all the birds in the forest were terrified and flew away. But the horse let him roar and never stopped till he stood before his master's door.
- 10 When the master saw him he was delighted and said to him: "You shall stay with me and have a good time as long as you live."
- 11 And he fed him well till he died.

"The Fox and the Horse"—Public Domain

21. Part A

Why does the horse decide to follow the fox’s plan without knowing what it is?

- A. because the horse has lost its self-confidence
- B. because the fox has helped him before
- C. because the fox knows where the lion’s den is
- D. because the horse is lonely

Part B

Which excerpt from the folktale supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “The poor horse was very sad” (paragraph 2)
- B. ““Why do you hang your head and wander about in this solitary fashion?”” (paragraph 2)
- C. “. . . if I was strong enough to bring him a lion he would keep me, but he knows well enough that the task is beyond me.” (paragraph 5)
- D. “The horse did as he was told, and the fox went to the lion’s den” (paragraph 6)

22. In paragraph 3, the horse tells the fox that **avarice and honesty cannot live together**.

The peasant, the fox, and the lion represent the traits in the folktale as shown in the chart. Write **one** piece of evidence in the appropriate box to support **each** trait.

Evidence:

The peasant drives the horse away after years of service.

The peasant offers no sympathy to the horse and gives the horse a task to prove himself.

The fox plays a trick on the lion.

The lion allows the fox to tie him to the horse in order get the promised meal.

The peasant takes back the horse and offers to feed him forever.

The lion roars angrily.

The fox offers to help the horse.

Character	Trait	Evidence
peasant	honesty	
lion	avarice	
fox	honesty	

23. Part A

Which **two** sentences belong in a summary of “The Fox and the Horse”?

- A. The old horse is sent away by its owner.
- B. The horse lay down as the fox told him to do.
- C. The horse receives help from a cunning fox.
- D. The peasant does not want to feed the old horse.
- E. The birds in the forest are frightened by the lion.
- F. The horse ignores the lion’s enraged roar.

Part B

Which **two** additional sentences belong in the summary in Part A?

- A. The horse was sad when his master turned him out.
- B. The fox promises the lion a special meal.
- C. The fox tricks the lion into being tied to the horse.
- D. The horse is able to bring a lion back to his master.
- E. The lion is in his den when the fox comes to trick him.
- F. The master forgot the horse’s many years of service.

24. Part A

Which statement **best** expresses a central idea in the folktale?

- A. Loyal friends can be trusted.
- B. Honest people are good friends.
- C. Individuals who show kindness are often treated the same way.
- D. Individuals can accomplish more with the help of others.

Part B

Which sentence from the folktale **best** demonstrates this idea?

- A. “A peasant once had a faithful horse, but it had grown old and could no longer do its work.” (paragraph 1)
- B. ““Only the poor consolation of telling me that if I was strong enough to bring him a lion he would keep me, but he knows well enough that the task is beyond me.”” (paragraph 5)
- C. “Then the horse sprang up and dragged the lion away behind him.” (paragraph 9)
- D. “When the master saw him he was delighted and said to him: ‘You shall stay with me and have a good time as long as you live.’” (paragraph 10)

- 25.** Beginning after paragraph 9, write an alternate ending to the folktale using details about the characters and events from the passage. You may choose to use dialogue in your new ending.

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Today you will read the myth “The Star and the Lily” and the myth “Apollo and Hyacinthus” about how two types of flowers received their names.

Read the myth “The Star and the Lily.” Then answer questions 26 through 28.

The Star and the Lily

by Hamilton Wright Mabie

- 1 An old chieftain sat in his wigwam, quietly smoking his favorite pipe, when a crowd of boys and girls suddenly entered, and, with numerous offerings of tobacco, begged him to tell them a story, and he did so.
- 2 There was once a time when this world was filled with happy people, when all the nations were as one, and the crimson tide of war had not begun to roll. Plenty of game was in the forest and on the plains. None were in want, for a full supply was at hand. Sickness was unknown. The beasts of the field were lame; they came and went at the bidding of man. One unending spring gave no place for winter—for its cold blasts or its unhealthy chills. Every tree and bush yielded fruit. Flowers carpeted the earth. The air was laden with their fragrance, and redolent with the songs of wedded warblers that flew from branch to branch, fearing none, for there were none to harm them. There were birds then of more beautiful song and plumage than now. It was such a time, when earth was a paradise and man worthily its possessor, that the Indians were lone inhabitants of the American Wilderness. They numbered millions; and living as nature designed them to live, enjoyed its many blessings. Instead of amusements in close rooms, the sport of the field was theirs. At night they met on the wide green beneath the heavenly worlds—the *ah-nung-o-kah*. They watched the stars; they loved to gaze at them, for they believed them to be the residences of the good, who had been taken home by the Great Spirit.
- 3 One night they saw one star that shone brighter than all others. Its location was far away in the south, near a mountain peak. For many nights it was seen, till at length it was doubted by many that the star was as far distant in the southern skies as it seemed to be. This doubt led to an examination, which proved the star to be only a short distance away, and near the tops of some trees. A number of warriors were deputed to go and see what it was. They went, and on their return said it appeared strange, and somewhat like a bird. A committee of the wise men were called to inquire into, and if possible to ascertain the meaning of, the strange phenomenon. They feared that it might be the omen of some disaster. Some thought it a precursor of good, others of evil; and some supposed it to be the star spoken of by their forefathers as the forerunner of a dreadful war.

GO ON ►

- 4 One moon had nearly gone by, and yet the mystery remained unsolved. One night a young warrior had a dream, in which a beautiful maiden came and stood at his side, and thus addressed him: “Young brave! Charmed with the land of my forefathers, its flowers, its birds, its rivers, its beautiful lakes, and its mountains clothed with green, I have left my sisters in yonder world to dwell among you. Young brave! ask your wise and your great men where I can live and see the happy race continually, ask them what form I shall assume in order to be loved.”
- 5 Thus discoursed the bright stranger. The young man awoke. On stepping out of his lodge, he saw the star yet blazing in its accustomed place. At early dawn the chief’s crier was sent round the camp to call every warrior to the council lodge. When they had met, the young warrior related his dream. They concluded that the star that had been seen in the south had fallen in love with mankind, and that it was desirous to dwell with them.
- 6 The next night five tall, noble-looking, adventurous braves were sent to welcome the stranger to earth. They went and presented to it a pipe of peace, filled with sweet-scented herbs, and were rejoiced that it took it from them. As they returned to the village, the star, with expanded wings, followed, and hovered over their homes till the dawn of day. Again it came to the young man in a dream, and desired to know where it should live and what form it should take. Places were named—on the top of giant trees, or in flowers. At length it was told to choose a place itself, and it did so. At first it dwelt in the white rose of the mountains; but there it was so buried that it could not be seen. It went to the prairie; but it feared the hoof of the buffalo. It next sought the rocky cliff, but there it was so high that the children, whom it loved most, could not see it.
- 7 “I know where I shall live,” said the bright fugitive—“where I can see the gliding canoe of the race I most admire. Children!—yes, they shall be my playmates, and I will kiss their slumber by the side of cool lakes. The nation shall love me wherever I am.”
- 8 These words having been said, she alighted on the waters, where she saw herself reflected. The next morning thousands of white flowers were seen on the surface of the lakes, and the Indians gave them this name, *wah-be-gwan-nee* (white flower).
- 9 This star lived in the southern skies. Her brethren can be seen far off in the cold north, hunting the Great Bear, whilst her sisters watch her in the east and west.
- 10 Children! When you see the lily on the waters, take it in your hands and hold it to the skies, that it may be happy on earth, as its two sisters, the morning and evening stars, are happy in heaven.

“The Star and the Lily” by Hamilton Wright Mabie – Public Domain

26. Part A

In “The Star and the Lily,” how does the young warrior’s first dream propel the action of the plot?

- A. It causes the Indians to send a number of warriors to go investigate the strange phenomenon.
- B. It motivates the star to experiment with several possible living spaces.
- C. It convinces the Indians not to fear the bright star as a bad omen, but to welcome it.
- D. It leads the star to hover with expanded wings over the homes of the village.

Part B

Which sentence from the myth supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “A number of warriors were deputed to go and see what it was.” (paragraph 3)
- B. “They concluded that the star that had been in the south had fallen in love with mankind, and that it was desirous to dwell with them.” (paragraph 5)
- C. “As they returned to the village, the star, with expanded wings, followed, and hovered over their homes till the dawn of day.” (paragraph 6)
- D. “At length it was told to choose a place itself, and it did so.” (paragraph 6)

27. Part A

What does the star's desire to live among the Indian people reveal about them?

- A. They have many superstitions that influence their decisions.
- B. They rely on their experienced elders for guidance.
- C. They value living harmoniously with their world.
- D. They are peace loving but also prepared for war.

Part B

What evidence from the passage **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. "They numbered millions; and living as nature designed them to live, enjoyed its many blessings." (paragraph 2)
- B. "A committee of the wise men were called to inquire into, and if possible to ascertain the meaning of, the strange phenomenon." (paragraph 3)
- C. "Some thought of it a precursor of good . . . and some supposed it to be the star spoken of by their forefathers as the forerunner of a dreadful war." (paragraph 3)
- D. "At early dawn the chief's crier was sent round the camp to call every warrior to the council lodge." (paragraph 5)

28. Circle **two** themes from “The Star and the Lily” from the list under THEMES. Then draw a line from each theme to one piece of evidence that supports it.

THEMES

Adventure can be found in unexpected places.

Persistence is often necessary to achieve a goal.

Friendship is difficult to obtain but is worth the effort.

People can gain knowledge through overcoming hardships.

The loss of innocence can change the way people view the world.

The origin of the natural world can be revealed through imaginative stories.

EVIDENCE

“It was such a time, when earth was a paradise and man worthily its possessor” (paragraph 2)

“Instead of amusements in close rooms, the sport of the field was theirs.” (paragraph 2)

“The next night five tall, noble-looking, adventurous braves were sent to welcome the stranger to earth.” (paragraph 6)

“Again it came to the young man in a dream, and desired to know where it should live and what form it should take. . . . At length it was told to choose a place itself, and it did so.” (paragraph 6)

“Children!—yes, they shall be my playmates, and I will kiss their slumber by the side of cool lakes.” (paragraph 7)

“The next morning thousands of white flowers were seen on the surface of the lakes, and the Indians gave them this name, *wah-be-gwan-nee* (white flower).” (paragraph 8)

GO ON ►

Read the myth “Apollo and Hyacinthus.” Then answer questions 29 and 30.

from “Apollo and Hyacinthus”

by Thomas Bulfinch

Apollo was passionately fond of a youth named Hyacinthus. He accompanied him in his sports, carried the nets when he went fishing, led the dogs when he went to hunt, followed him in his excursions in the mountains, and neglected for him his lyre and his arrows. One day they played a game of quoits together, and Apollo, heaving aloft the discus, with strength mingled with skill, sent it high and far. Hyacinthus watched it as it flew, and excited with the sport, ran forward to seize it, eager to make his throw, when the quoit bounded from the earth and struck him in the forehead. He fainted and fell. The god, as pale as himself, raised him and tried all his art to stanch the wound and retain the flitting life, but all in vain; the hurt was past the power of medicine. As, when one has broken the stem of a lily in the garden, it hangs its head and turns its flowers to the earth, so the head of the dying boy, as if too heavy for his neck, fell over on his shoulder. “Thou diest, Hyacinth,” so spoke Phoebus, “robbed of thy youth by me. Thine is the suffering, mine the crime. Would that I could die for thee! But since that may not be, thou shalt live with me in memory and in song. My lyre shall celebrate thee, my song shall tell thy fate, and thou shalt become a flower inscribed with my regrets.” While Apollo spoke, behold the blood which had flowed on the ground and stained the herbage, ceased to be blood; but a flower of hue more beautiful than the Tyrian sprang up, resembling the lily, if it were not that this is purple and that silvery white.¹ And this was not enough for Phoebus; but to confer still greater honor, he marked the petals with his sorrow, and inscribed “Ah! Ah!” upon them, as we see to this day. The flower bears the name of Hyacinthus, and with every returning spring revives the memory of his fate.

¹ It is evidently not our modern hyacinth that is here described. It is perhaps some species of iris, or perhaps of larkspur, or of pansy.

“Apollo and Hyacinthus” from THE AGE OF FABLE by Thomas Bulfinch—Public Domain

29. Part A

What does the phrase **flitting life** imply in “Apollo and Hyacinthus”?

- A. Hyacinthus wants to play a different sport.
- B. Hyacinthus is a faster runner than Apollo.
- C. Hyacinthus is so badly injured he might die.
- D. Hyacinthus is injured but able to play again.

Part B

Which **two** phrases help the reader understand the meaning of **flitting life** in “Apollo and Hyacinthus”?

- A. “. . . strength mingled with skill”
- B. “. . . bounded from the earth”
- C. “The god, as pale as himself”
- D. “. . . stanch the wound and retain”
- E. “. . . the hurt was past the power of medicine.”
- F. “. . . its flowers to the earth”

30. Part A

Which phrase states a central idea in “Apollo and Hyacinthus”?

- A. resolving family conflict
- B. coping with grief and loss
- C. finding one’s calling
- D. facing one’s fears

Part B

Which piece of evidence from the myth supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “Hyacinthus watched it as it flew, and excited with the sport, ran forward to seize it”
- B. ““My lyre shall celebrate thee . . . and thou shalt become a flower inscribed with my regrets.””
- C. “. . . but a flower of hue more beautiful than the Tyrian sprang up”
- D. “It is perhaps some species of iris, or perhaps of larkspur”

Refer to the myths “The Star and the Lily” and “Apollo and Hyacinthus.” Then answer question 31.

31. Part A

Which story-telling technique does the author of “The Star and the Lily” use that the author of “Apollo and Hyacinthus” does **not** use?

- A. He retells a traditional tale that explains the origin of well-known natural phenomenon.
- B. He interrupts his fanciful story with a factual aside.
- C. He includes a frame story in which the supposed traditional storyteller appears as a character.
- D. He includes old-fashioned language in the dialogue to suggest the events took place long ago.

Part B

Which detail from “The Star and the Lily” supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “An old chieftain sat in his wigwam, quietly smoking his favorite pipe, when a crowd of Indian boys and girls suddenly entered, and, . . . , begged him to tell them a story” (paragraph 1)
- B. “Its location was far away in the south, near a mountain” (paragraph 3)
- C. “‘I know where I shall live,’ said the bright fugitive” (paragraph 7)
- D. “The next morning thousands of white flowers were seen on the surface of the lakes, and the Indians gave them this name, *wah-be-gwan-nee*” (paragraph 8)



Session 4

Reading Literary and Informational Texts

Directions:

Today you will take Session 4 of the Grade 8 English Language Arts Practice Test.

Read each passage and question. Then follow the directions to answer each question. Mark your answers by **circling** the correct choices in your test booklet. If you need to change an answer, be sure to erase your first answer completely.

If you do not know the answer to a question, you may go on to the next question. If you finish early, you may review your answers and any questions you did not answer in this session **ONLY**.

GO ON ►

Read the passage from *Chew On This*. Then answer questions 32 through 35.

from *Chew On This*

by Eric Schlosser and Charles Wilson

- 1 As a child in the 1950s, Alice Waters was a picky eater. She didn't like foods with thick sauces. She didn't like stews, creamy spinach, or overcooked meat. She liked simple things, like the fruits and vegetables her father grew in the backyard garden of their little house in Chatham, New Jersey. Her family didn't have a lot of money, so they didn't go to restaurants frequently. They ate meals at the dining room table. Alice didn't like the food at school, and in those days kids were allowed to eat in the cafeteria or go home for lunch. Most days Alice went home. She was picky but still enjoyed eating certain junk foods every now and then: potato chips, orange soda, jelly doughnuts, chili cheeseburgers.
- 2 Alice moved to Berkeley, California, for college. The University of California at Berkeley was known for its radical thinking, for students who liked to make waves and challenge conventional wisdom. During the 1960s, Berkeley students campaigned for racial equality, for women's rights, for an end to the war in Vietnam. Alice fit in well at Berkeley; there was nothing ordinary about her. At the age of nineteen she took a year off and lived in France. The experience changed her forever. She fell in love with the food there. She felt like she'd never eaten before. The people she met in France cared intensely about food, about how it was bought and sold and prepared and served at the table. Meals were more than a way to fill your belly. They were a way to enjoy conversation, family, and friendship. They weren't something rushed and soon forgotten. They were meant to bring people together.
- 3 Alice returned home determined to learn how to cook. She wanted to introduce the United States to a whole new outlook on food. She studied French cookbooks and started making meals for friends. And then, in 1971, she opened a restaurant in Berkeley and gave it a French name: Chez Panisse. At the restaurant she offered food that was simple and fresh, food that mainly got its taste not from fancy sauces and seasonings but from the quality of the basic ingredients. Alice always sought out the best-tasting tomatoes, the best peaches, the best plums. When she couldn't buy them at the market, she found people to grow them for her. She formed close ties with local farmers and ranchers, refusing to buy food that was out of season or that had been transported thousands of miles. The food she bought had to be organic, locally produced, and delicious.

GO ON ►

- 4 Chez Panisse was soon considered one of the finest restaurants in the United States, and Alice Waters was hailed as one of the nation's greatest chefs. She was a true radical—not the kind who wants to destroy things or tear them down, but the kind who looks past the surface to the fundamental nature of things. During the same years that fast-food chains were turning restaurant kitchens into little factories and live-stock into industrial commodities, Alice championed an old-fashioned view of food. It stood for a different set of American values: honesty, integrity, wholesomeness, and, most of all, community.
- 5 Every day, while driving to Chez Panisse in the morning and driving home late at night, Alice passed Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School. It seemed like a sad place, with graffiti on the windows and burned-out grass on the lawn. Although students still attended classes there, the school looked neglected. Alice wondered how the people of Berkeley, who considered themselves so high-minded and aware, could allow a public school to fall apart this way. She made this point during a newspaper interview, and not long afterward got a call from Neil Smith, the school's principal. He invited her to Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School and asked her to help beautify the place.
- 6 During a visit to the school, Alice became less concerned about how the place looked—and much more concerned about what the kids were being fed there. Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School had been built in the 1920s to educate five hundred children. Now it had about twice that many students. The cafeteria was too small to feed so many kids. It had been shut down for years and was being used to store old tables and chairs. There was still nasty old leftover food in the ovens. Lunch was served at a snack bar on the edge of the playground. Alice watched kids standing around eating reheated frozen hamburgers, chicken nuggets, and fries. She was appalled. The sight of the abandoned cafeteria and the cheap fast food made her realize that something had to be done right away to change the way these kids thought about food. And she decided to do it.
- 7 Twelve years after Alice's first visit to Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School, it has the most innovative and remarkable food program in the United States. Called the Edible Schoolyard, it doesn't just provide healthy, nutritious meals. It gives kids a firsthand education in the role that food plays in society. It teaches skills they can use for the rest of their lives. After raising money through her Chez Panisse Foundation, Alice supervised the planting of an enormous garden at Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School. An acre of asphalt was torn up, topsoil was hauled in, and all sorts of plants, flowers, fruit trees, and vines were planted. Today this school garden produces strawberries, potatoes, tomatoes, lettuce, herbs, beans, corn, pumpkins, asparagus, broccoli, beets, carrots, garlic, cucumbers, peppers, cabbage, and Brussels sprouts, among other things. There's a chicken coop where hens can wander freely and lay eggs. There's a wood-burning outdoor oven for cooking pizza and baking bread. The place looks like a small farm in the heart of a lovely town.

- 8 The sixth-, seventh-, and eighth-graders at Martin Luther King Jr. come from a wide variety of backgrounds. About twenty different languages are spoken at students' homes. Roughly one third of the kids are African American, one third are white, and the rest are mainly Asian or Latino. All of them have to work in the garden, planting, tending, and harvesting food. And all of them have to work in the school's new kitchen, learning how to prepare food, how to serve it, and how to clean up after everybody's eaten it. Esther Cook, the chef-teacher at the Edible Schoolyard, has thought up many ingenious ways to combine cooking and gardening with learning. In the classroom, food-related subjects are used to help teach science, history, and ecology. A science project might involve earthworms in the garden; a history project might unfold in the kitchen, with samples of what European serfs ate during the Middle Ages. Teachers work with their students in the garden and the kitchen. At Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School, food isn't something you scarf down quickly and then forget about. It's an integral part of daily life.

Excerpt from CHEW ON THIS by Eric Schlosser and Charles Wilson. Text 2006 by Eric Schlosser. Reprinted by permission of Houghton Mifflin Harcourt Publishing Company. All rights reserved.

32. Part A

Which idea is introduced in paragraph 1 of the passage?

- A. Alice was given very unusual foods to eat as a child.
- B. Alice liked different kinds of food than kids do today.
- C. Alice’s childhood helped shape her attitudes about food.
- D. Alice’s attitudes about cafeteria food changed over time.

Part B

Which quotation from paragraph 1 **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “As a child in the 1950s, Alice Waters was a picky eater.”
- B. “She liked simple things, like the fruits and vegetables her father grew in the backyard garden”
- C. “They ate meals at the dining room table.”
- D. “Alice didn’t like the food at school”

33. Part A

Which part of Alice’s life **most** inspired her to create the Edible Schoolyard?

- A. her picky eating
- B. her family garden
- C. her trip to France
- D. her move to Berkeley

Part B

Which sentence from the passage **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “Her family didn’t have a lot of money, so they didn’t go to restaurants frequently.” (paragraph 1)
- B. “She was picky but still enjoyed eating certain junk foods every now and then: potato chips, orange soda, jelly doughnuts, chili cheeseburgers.” (paragraph 1)
- C. “Alice fit in well at Berkeley; there was nothing ordinary about her.” (paragraph 2)
- D. “The people she met in France cared intensely about food, about how it was bought and sold and prepared and served at the table.” (paragraph 2)

GO ON ►

34. Part A

How do the authors support the claim that food is an essential part of life?

- A. by explaining how fresh foods can be grown on school land
- B. by describing some of the foods that students have grown
- C. by describing what students can learn about the world from food
- D. by explaining how a school decided to start growing its own food

Part B

Which sentence from the passage **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “Lunch was served at a snack bar on the edge of the playground.” (paragraph 6)
- B. “Called the Edible Schoolyard, it doesn’t just provide healthy, nutritious meals.” (paragraph 7)
- C. “An acre of asphalt was torn up, topsoil was hauled in, and all sorts of plants, flowers, fruit trees, and vines were planted.” (paragraph 7)
- D. “A science project might involve earthworms in the garden; a history project might unfold in the kitchen, with samples of what European serfs ate during the Middle Ages.” (paragraph 8)

35. Part A

Based on the passage, which statement **most likely** describes the authors' view of Alice Waters?

- A. She is a loyal friend.
- B. She is a patient employer.
- C. She is a concerned citizen.
- D. She is a demanding perfectionist.

Part B

Which **two** sentences from the passage **best** support the answer to Part A?

- A. "Alice returned home determined to learn how to cook." (paragraph 3)
- B. "Chez Panisse was soon considered one of the finest restaurants in the United States, and Alice Waters was hailed as one of the nation's greatest chefs." (paragraph 4)
- C. "During the same years that fast-food chains were turning restaurant kitchens into little factories and live-stock into industrial commodities, Alice championed an old-fashioned view of food." (paragraph 4)
- D. "Every day, while driving to Chez Panisse in the morning and driving home late at night, Alice passed Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School." (paragraph 5)
- E. "Alice wondered how the people of Berkeley, who considered themselves so high-minded and aware, could allow a public school to fall apart this way." (paragraph 5)
- F. "After raising money through her Chez Panisse Foundation, Alice supervised the planting of an enormous garden at Martin Luther King Jr. Middle School." (paragraph 7)

Read the passage from “What is a Robonaut?” Then answer questions 36 through 41.

from “What is a Robonaut?”

- 1 A Robonaut is a dexterous humanoid robot built and designed at NASA Johnson Space Center in Houston, Texas. Our challenge is to build machines that can help humans work and explore in space. Working side by side with humans, or going where the risks are too great for people, Robonauts will expand our ability for construction and discovery. Central to that effort is a capability we call dexterous manipulation, embodied by an ability to use one’s hand to do work, and our challenge has been to build machines with dexterity that exceeds that of a suited astronaut.
- 2 There are currently four Robonauts, with others in development. This allows us to study various types of mobility, control methods, and task applications. The value of a humanoid over other designs is the ability to use the same workspace and tools—not only does this improve efficiency in the types of tools, but also removes the need for specialized robotic connectors. Robonauts are essential to NASA’s future as we go beyond low earth orbit and continue to explore the vast wonder that is space.
- 3 Robonaut 2 or R2, launched to the International Space Station on space shuttle Discovery as part of the STS-133 mission, is the first dexterous humanoid robot in space, and the first U.S.-built robot at the space station. But that was just one small step for a robot and one giant leap for robot-kind.
- 4 Initially R2 will be deployed on a fixed pedestal inside the ISS¹. Next steps include a leg for climbing through the corridors of the Space Station, upgrades for R2 to go outside into the vacuum of space, and then future lower bodies like legs and wheels to propel the R2 across Lunar and Martian terrain. A four-wheeled rover called Centaur 2 is being evaluated at the 2010 Desert Field Test in Arizona as an example of these future lower bodies for R2.

Robonaut 2

- 5 In the current iteration of Robonaut, Robonaut 2, or R2, NASA and General Motors are working together with assistance from Oceaneering Space Systems engineers to accelerate development of the next generation of robots and related technologies for use in the automotive and aerospace industries. Robonaut 2 (R2) is a state of the art highly dexterous anthropomorphic robot. Like its predecessor Robonaut 1 (R1), R2 is capable of handling a wide range of EVA² tools and interfaces, but R2 is a significant advancement over its predecessor. R2 is capable of speeds more than four times faster than R1, is more compact, is more dexterous, and includes a deeper and wider range

¹ ISS—International Space Station

² EVA—extra-vehicular activity, activity done by an astronaut outside a spacecraft beyond Earth’s atmosphere

of sensing. Advanced technology spans the entire R2 system and includes: optimized overlapping dual arm dexterous workspace, series elastic joint technology, extended finger and thumb travel, miniaturized 6-axis load cells, redundant force sensing, ultra-high speed joint controllers, extreme neck travel, and high resolution camera and IR³ systems. The dexterity of R2 allows it to use the same tools that astronauts currently use and removes the need for specialized tools just for robots.

- 6 One advantage of a humanoid design is that Robonaut can take over simple, repetitive, or especially dangerous tasks on places such as the International Space Station. Because R2 is approaching human dexterity, tasks such as changing out an air filter can be performed without modifications to the existing design.
- 7 Another way this might be beneficial is during a robotic precursor mission. R2 would bring one set of tools for the precursor mission, such as setup and geologic investigation. Not only does this improve efficiency in the types of tools, but also removes the need for specialized robotic connectors. Future missions could then supply a new set of tools and use the existing tools already on location.

³IR—industrial tools

from What is a Robonaut? by NASA—Public Domain

36. Part A

The word **dexterous** is used several times in the passage. What is the meaning of **dexterous** as used in the passage?

- A. skillful
- B. experienced
- C. intelligent
- D. quick

Part B

Circle **three** details from paragraphs 1–5 that support the answer to Part A.

- A. “. . . ability to use one’s hand” (paragraph 1)
- B. “. . . ability to use the same workspace and tools” (paragraph 2)
- C. “. . . removes the need for specialized robotic connectors.” (paragraph 2)
- D. “. . . future lower bodies like legs and wheels” (paragraph 4)
- E. “. . . accelerate development of the next generation of robots” (paragraph 5)
- F. “. . . capable of handling a wide range of EVA tools and interfaces” (paragraph 5)
- G. “. . . capable of speeds more than four times faster than R1.” (paragraph 5)

37. Part A

Paragraph 3 contains an allusion to American astronaut Neil Armstrong’s statement when, as the first person ever to walk on the Moon, he said: “That’s one small step for man, one giant leap for mankind.”

What is the author implying by the allusion to Armstrong’s statement in paragraph 3?

- A. Like Armstrong’s Moon landing, the launch of the first Robonaut aboard the Discovery represents a historic breakthrough in space exploration.
- B. The use of R2 aboard the International Space Station will make space exploration safer for astronauts in the future.
- C. In the future, human astronauts like Neil Armstrong will unfortunately be replaced with humanoid robots like R2.
- D. Compared to the launch of R2 aboard the space shuttle Discovery, Neil Armstrong’s Moon landing was only a minor achievement.

Part B

Which piece of evidence from the passage **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “. . . our challenge has been to build machines with dexterity that exceeds that of a suited astronaut.” (paragraph 1)
- B. “. . . not only does this improve efficiency in the types of tools, but also removes the need for specialized robotic connectors.” (paragraph 2)
- C. “Next steps include a leg for climbing through the corridors of the Space Station . . .” (paragraph 4)
- D. “Robonaut can take over simple, repetitive, or especially dangerous tasks . . .” (paragraph 6)

38. Part A

Why does the author explain Robonauts' abilities in detail?

- A. to outline the history of Robonauts' development
- B. to demonstrate the benefits of using Robonauts in space
- C. to explain how Robonauts might be useful in everyday life
- D. to persuade readers that Robonauts' skills have applications for other types of work beyond space exploration

Part B

Which detail from the passage supports the answer to Part A?

- A. "Robonauts are essential to NASA's future" (paragraph 2)
- B. "But that was just one small step for a robot" (paragraph 3)
- C. ". . . Centaur 2 is being evaluated . . . as an example of these future lower bodies" (paragraph 4)
- D. ". . . for use in the automotive and aerospace industries." (paragraph 5)

39. Part A

How does paragraph 4 contribute to the topic of the passage?

- A. It explains some improvements planned for the R2 to make it more useful.
- B. It adds details about the R2 that was launched on the space shuttle.
- C. It provides a comparison between the R2 and previous models.
- D. It states conclusions about the value of having the R2 on space missions.

Part B

Which additional paragraph contributes to the development of the topic in a similar way?

- A. paragraph 2
- B. paragraph 3
- C. paragraph 5
- D. paragraph 6

40. Identify each detail from the passage as a fact, a judgment based on research findings, or a speculation. Circle the correct word for each detail.

“The value of a humanoid over other designs is the ability to use the same workspace and tools”	Fact
	Judgment
	Speculation
“. . . it is the first dexterous humanoid robot in space”	Fact
	Judgment
	Speculation
“. . . NASA and General Motors are working together with assistance from Oceaneering Space Systems engineers to accelerate development of the next generation of robots”	Fact
	Judgment
	Speculation
“Another way this might be beneficial is during a robotic precursor mission.”	Fact
	Judgment
	Speculation

41. Part A

What is one central idea that is developed in the passage?

- A. Robonauts can work more efficiently than astronauts.
- B. Use of robonauts will replace astronauts in space travel.
- C. Robonauts can make more reliable decisions about spacecraft maintenance than humans.
- D. Use of robonauts will allow space exploration to exceed what humans alone can do.

Part B

Which detail from the passage **best** supports the answer to Part A?

- A. “. . . going where the risks are too great for people” (paragraph 1)
- B. “. . . includes a deeper and wider range of sensing.” (paragraph 5)
- C. “. . . allows it to use the same tools that astronauts currently use” (paragraph 5)
- D. “. . . tasks such as changing out an air filter can be performed without modifications to the existing design.” (paragraph 6)



This document contains the answers to all items on the grade 8 ELA Practice Test, as well as alignment and scoring information. Refer to the [ELA Practice Test Guidance](#) for information on how to incorporate the practice tests into instruction, as well as a scoring activity.

Although the actual test contains only three sessions and two tasks—a Research Simulation Task (RST) AND a Literary Analysis Task (LAT) OR a Narrative Writing Task (NWT)—the practice test includes four sessions and all three tasks so students can address Writing standards 1, 2, and 3. See the [Grade 8 ELA Assessment Guide](#) for more information about the test’s design.

Session	Sequence	Item Type	Key	Alignment
1 Literary Analysis Task	1	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: B	L.8.4, RL.8.4, RL.8.1
	2	EBSR	PART A: D PART B: C	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	3	TE	PART A: B PART B: See TE Item Key	RL.8.4, RL.8.1
	4	TE	PART A: D PART B: See TE Item Key	RL.8.2, RL.8.1
	5	EBSR	PART A: D PART B: A	RL.8.3, RL.8.5, RL.8.1
	6	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: D	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	7	PCR	See Scoring Table and Rubric	RL.8.6, RL.8.3, RL.8.1; W.8.2, W.8.4, W.8.9; L.8.1, L.8.2
1 Reading Passage Set	8	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: D	RI.8.5, RI.8.1
	9	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: A	RI.8.6, RI.8.5, RI.8.1

Session	Sequence	Item Type	Key	Alignment
	10	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: D	RI.8.4, L.8.4, RI.8.1
	11	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: A	RI.8.2, RI.8.1
2 Research Simulation Task	12	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: D	RI.8.4, L.8.4, RI.8.1
	13	MS	PART A: B PART B: A, C	RI.8.2, RI.8.1
	14	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: C	RI.8.5, RI.8.1
	15	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: A	RI.8.4, L.8.4, RI.8.1
	16	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: C	RI.8.3, RI.8.1
	17	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: C	RI.8.4, L.8.4, RI.8.1
	18	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: B	RI.8.5, RI.8.1
	19	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: A	RI.8.2, RI.8.1
	20	PCR	See Scoring Table and Rubric Sample Student Responses	RI.8.3, RI.8.1; W.8.2, W.8.4, W.8.9; L.8.1, L.8.2
3 Narrative Writing Task	21	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: C	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	22	TE	See TE Item Key	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	23	MS	PART A: A, C PART B: C, D	RL.8.2, RL.8.1
	24	EBSR	PART A: D PART B: C	RL.8.2, RL.8.1
	25	PCR	See Scoring Table and Rubric Sample Student Responses	W.8.3, W.8.4; L.8.1, L.8.2

Session	Sequence	Item Type	Key	Alignment
3 Reading Passage Set	26	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: B	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	27	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: A	RL.8.3, RL.8.1
	28	TE	See TE Item Key	RL.8.2, RL.8.1
	29	MS	PART A: C PART B: D, E	RL.8.4, L.8.4, RL.8.1
	30	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: B	RL.8.2, RL.8.1
	31	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: A	RL.8.5, RL.8.1
4 Reading Literary and Informational Texts	32	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: B	RI.8.2, RI.8.1
	33	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: D	RI.8.3, RI.8.1
	34	EBSR	PART A: C PART B: D	RI.8.8, RI.8.1
	35	MS	PART A: C PART B: E, F	RI.8.6, RI.8.1
	36	MS	PART A: A PART B: A, B, F	RI.8.4, L.8.4, RI.8.1
	37	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: D	RI.8.5, RI.8.4, RI.8.1
	38	EBSR	PART A: B PART B: A	RI.8.6, RI.8.1
	39	EBSR	PART A: A PART B: C	RI.8.5, RI.8.1
	40	TE	See TE Item Key	RI.8.9, RI.8.1
	41	EBSR	PART A: D PART B: A	RI.8.2, RI.8.1

Item Type	Description	Scoring Information
Evidence-Based Selected Response (EBSR)	- Two-part item - Part A measures reading comprehension - Part B asks for evidence to support part A	- Worth up to two points (2, 1, or 0) - Full credit (2 points): both parts correct - Partial credit (1 point): Part A is correct; Part B is not correct - No credit (0 points): only Part B is correct or neither part is correct
Multiple-Select (MS)	- Requires more than one answer (required number of correct answers in boldface in question) - Can have one part (e.g., asks student to select three summary details) or two parts (e.g., Part A asks students to choose two themes; Part B asks for evidence for themes)	- Worth up to two points (2, 1, or 0) - Full credit (2 points): All answers correct - Partial credit (1 point): for one-part MS item, 1 of 2 or 2 of 3 answers are correct or for an EBSR with MS in Part A, 1 of 2 or 2 of 3 answers in Part A are correct OR all answers are correct in part A, but Part B is incorrect - No credit (0 points): Both parts are incorrect OR only Part B is correct
Technology-Enhanced (TE)	- May have one part OR be part of an EBSR item - Types: Drag and drop, drop-down menu, highlighting words/phrases/sentences, matching information (refer to LEAP 2025 Technology Enhanced Item Types document for more information)	- Worth up to two points (2, 1, or 0) - TE Items that are part of an EBSR follow the same general rules as EBSR items. - Full credit (2 points): all correct responses—whether one or two parts—and ordered correctly, if required, OR if the item includes six or more correct responses, full credit when student chooses all or nearly all correct responses (number of correct responses minus 1) - Partial credit (1 point): depends on item type - For most one-part TE items: 1 point if student chooses at least half of the correct responses - For one-part TE items that require paired responses: 1 point when student chooses at least half of the correctly paired responses - For one-part TE items that require ordering (e.g., steps in a process): 1 point when a student chooses and correctly orders more than half of the correct responses - For summary items that include at least two extra options (e.g., 6 summary details, but student has to choose and order 4 correctly): 1 point when student chooses all of the correct

		responses but does not place them in the correct order OR when student chooses and correctly orders more than half of the correct responses No credit (0 points): does not meet partial credit rules or for a two-part TE item, only part B is correct
Prose Constructed Response (PCR)	- Requires student to show understanding of text(s) by writing a multi-paragraph response - Addresses more than one text depending on the task (LAT: 2 texts; RST: 3 texts) - Requires evidence from texts - Measures Reading Comprehension and Written Expression, and Knowledge of Language and Conventions (LAT and RST); measures Written Expression and Knowledge of Language and Conventions (NWT)	LAT/RST: Worth up to 19 points - Reading Comprehension and Written Expression dimension: score point of 4, 3, 2, 1, 0; holistic score is multiplied by 4 to provide total dimension score - Knowledge of Language and Conventions dimension (3, 2, 1, 0) NWT: Worth up to 15 points - Written Expression dimension: score point of 4, 3, 2, 1, 0; holistic score is multiplied by 3 to provide total dimension score - Knowledge of Language and Conventions dimension (3, 2, 1, 0)

Key for Technology-Enhanced Items

Session 1, Item 3

- 32 "I was going to try and find some girls my age here in the complex so I wouldn't have to be the new kid in school," I said, trying to sound believable.
- 33 "Honey, you can make friends at your new school in the fall. Besides, this is a wonderful opportunity for you."
- 34 "Opportunity? For me? Or for you?"
- 36 I reached for a story card and scribbled:
- 37 ***Gypsy was sent to prison for stealing the magic ball. And when she was tossed into the dungeon below the castle she found the word "opportunity" written across the stone wall.***
- 38 Staring at the card, I wondered what should happen next. Maybe a daring escape or a sorceress could rescue her. When nothing came to me, I scratched out the word *opportunity* until it was a big blob of blue ink and tossed the card on the floor.
- 39 I heard Mom's footsteps coming toward my closed bedroom door. I held my breath, hoping she wouldn't knock.

Session 1, Item 4

Mom leaned back against the counter and sucked in a great gulp of air. "It's strange actually. I wasn't expecting it, but then at the last minute the funding came through." She folded her arms across her waist, "I'm going to Costa Rica to finish my research." (paragraph 9)

"Opportunity? For me? Or for you?" (paragraph 34)

"I think you're going to like the village." Her voice became a little muffled now, like her mouth was pressed right up against the door. "It's strange and beautiful at the same time and a perfect place to explore. You just might be surprised what you find there." She paused for a moment then continued. "Would you please talk to me?" (paragraph 45)

Clang cla-clang, clang clang. The next morning, I found Mom in the kitchen with a chisel and hammer, chipping away at the kitchen counter. Little flecks of white flew through the air like ceramic snow, landing softly on her olive-colored cheeks. (paragraph 1)

She stepped back and surveyed the half-demolished counter the way someone stands back to study a newly hung photograph. Wiping her cheek with the back of her hand she said, "There was this"—she searched the mess on the floor—"this one broken tile poking out and I thought I should fix it and . . ." (paragraph 5)

Suddenly last night's phone call made perfect sense. I inched closer and pushed at the broken tile with my toes. (paragraph 17)

"You're going to New Mexico and that's final." (paragraph 28)

Note: The image on the next page shows the question prior to a response being entered.

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Session 3, Item 22

Character	Trait	Evidence
peasant	honesty	The peasant takes back the horse and offers to feed him forever.
lion	avarice	The lion allows the fox to tie him to the horse in order to get the promised meal.
fox	honesty	The fox offers to help the horse.

Evidence

The peasant drives the horse away after years of service.

The peasant offers no sympathy to the horse and gives the horse a task to prove himself.

The fox plays a trick on the lion.

The lion roars angrily.

Note: The image on the next page shows the question prior to a response being entered.

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The lion roars angrily.

The peasant takes back the horse and offers to feed him forever.

The fox offers to help the horse.

Session 3, Item 28*

THEMES	EVIDENCE
Persistence is often necessary to achieve a goal.	“Again it came to the young man in a dream, and desired to know where it should live and what form it should take. . . . At length it was told to choose a place itself, and it did so.” (paragraph 6)
The origin of the natural world can be revealed through imaginative stories.	“The next morning thousands of white flowers were seen on the surface of the lakes, and the Indians gave them this name, <i>wah-be-gwan-nee</i> (white flower).” (paragraph 8)

THEMES

Adventure can be found in unexpected places.

Friendship is difficult to obtain but is worth the effort.

People can gain knowledge through overcoming hardships.

The loss of innocence can change the way people view the world.

EVIDENCE

“It was such a time, when earth was a paradise and man worthily its possessor...” (paragraph 2)

“Instead of amusements in close rooms, the sport of the field was theirs.” (paragraph 2)

“The next night five tall, noble-looking, adventurous braves were sent to welcome the stranger to earth.” (paragraph 6)

“Children!—yes, they shall be my playmates, and I will kiss their slumber by the side of cool lakes.” (paragraph 7)

*The evidence needs to be placed beside the correct theme, but the themes do not need to be in a particular order.

Note: The image on the next page shows the question prior to a response being entered.

THEMES	EVIDENCE

THEMES

Adventure can be found in unexpected places.

Persistence is often necessary to achieve a goal.

Friendship is difficult to obtain but is worth the effort.

People can gain knowledge through overcoming hardships.

The loss of innocence can change the way people view the world.

The origin of the natural world can be revealed through imaginative stories.

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“Children!—yes, they shall be my playmates, and I will kiss their slumber by the side of cool lakes.” (paragraph 7)

“The next morning thousands of white flowers were seen on the surface of the lakes, and the Indians gave them this name, *wah-be-gwan-nee* (white flower).” (paragraph 8)

Session 4, Item 40

"The value of a humanoid over other designs is the ability to use the same workspace and tools"

Judgment ▼

". . . it is the first dexterous humanoid robot in space" Fact ▼

". . . NASA and General Motors are working together with assistance from Oceaneering Space Systems engineers to accelerate development of the next generation of robots" Fact ▼

"Another way this might be beneficial is during a robotic precursor mission." Speculation ▼

Scoring of Grade 8 PCRs				
Task	Dimensions	Points by Dimension	Total Points	Rubric
Literary Analysis	Reading Comprehension and Written Expression*	16 points (4 times holistic score)	19	LAT/RST Rubric
	Conventions	3 points		
Research Simulation	Reading Comprehension and Written Expression*	16 points (4 times holistic score)	19	LAT/RST Rubric
	Conventions	3 points		
Narrative Writing	Written Expression	12 points (3 times holistic score)	15	NWT Rubric
	Conventions	3 points		

*When scoring the Reading Comprehension and Written Expression dimension, the holistic score (4, 3, 2, 1, 0) is determined, based on which score point best describes that response. That holistic score is multiplied by 4. This means that if a student receives a 2 for Reading Comprehension and Written Expression, the student will receive a score of 8 for this dimension. This score is then added to the Conventions score to provide the total score for the RST and the LAT.

Grades 6–10 Literary Analysis Task (LAT) and Research Simulation Task (RST) Scoring Rubric

Construct Measured	Score Point 4	Score Point 3	Score Point 2	Score Point 1	Score Point 0
Reading Comprehension and Written Expression	The student response - demonstrates full comprehension of ideas stated explicitly and inferentially by providing an accurate analysis; - addresses the prompt and provides effective and comprehensive development of the claim or topic that is consistently appropriate to the task, purpose, and audience; - uses clear reasoning supported by relevant text-based evidence in the development of the claim or topic; - is effectively organized with clear and coherent writing; - establishes and maintains an effective style.	The student response - demonstrates comprehension of ideas stated explicitly and/or inferentially by providing a mostly accurate analysis; - addresses the prompt and provides mostly effective development of the claim or topic that is mostly appropriate to the task, purpose, and audience; - uses mostly clear reasoning supported by relevant text-based evidence in the development of the claim or topic; - is organized with mostly clear and coherent writing; - establishes and maintains a mostly effective style.	The student response - demonstrates basic comprehension of ideas stated explicitly and/or inferentially by providing a generally accurate analysis; - addresses the prompt and provides some development of the claim or topic that is somewhat appropriate to the task, purpose, and audience; - uses some reasoning and text-based evidence in the development of the claim or topic; - demonstrates some organization with somewhat coherent writing; - has a style that is somewhat effective.	The student response - demonstrates limited comprehension of ideas stated explicitly and/or inferentially by providing a minimally accurate analysis; - addresses the prompt and provides minimal development of the claim or topic that is limited in its appropriateness to the task, purpose, and audience; - uses limited reasoning and text-based evidence; - demonstrates limited organization and coherence; - has a style that is minimally effective.	The student response - demonstrates no comprehension of ideas by providing an inaccurate or no analysis; - is undeveloped and/or inappropriate to the task, purpose, and audience; - includes little to no text-based evidence; lacks organization and coherence; - has an inappropriate style.
Knowledge of Language and Conventions		The student response demonstrates full command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be a few minor errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage, but meaning is clear.	The student response demonstrates some command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage that occasionally impede understanding, but the meaning is generally clear.	The student response demonstrates limited command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage that often impede understanding.	The student response does not demonstrate command of the conventions of standard English at the appropriate level of complexity. Frequent and varied errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage impede understanding.

Grades 6–10 Narrative Writing Task (NWT) Scoring Rubric

Construct Measured	Score Point 4	Score Point 3	Score Point 2	Score Point 1	Score Point 0
Written Expression	The student response - is effectively developed with narrative elements and is consistently appropriate to the task; - is effectively organized with clear and coherent writing; - establishes and maintains an effective style.	The student response - is mostly effectively developed with narrative elements and is mostly appropriate to the task; - is organized with mostly clear and coherent writing; - establishes and maintains a mostly effective style.	The student response - is developed with some narrative elements and is generally appropriate to the task; - demonstrates some organization with somewhat coherent writing; - has a style that is somewhat effective.	The student response - is minimally developed with few narrative elements and is limited in its appropriateness to the task; - demonstrates limited organization and coherence; - has a style that has limited effectiveness.	The student response - is undeveloped and/or inappropriate to the task; lacks organization and coherence; - has an inappropriate style.
Knowledge of Language and Conventions		The student response demonstrates full command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be a few minor errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage, but meaning is clear.	The student response demonstrates some command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage that occasionally impede understanding, but the meaning is generally clear.	The student response demonstrates limited command of the conventions of standard English at an appropriate level of complexity. There may be errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage that often impede understanding.	The student response does not demonstrate command of the conventions of standard English at the appropriate level of complexity. Frequent and varied errors in mechanics, grammar, and usage impede understanding.

NOTES:

- The reading dimension is **not** scored for elicited narrative stories.
- The elements of coherence, clarity, and cohesion to be assessed are expressed in the grade-level standards W1-W4.
- Tone is not assessed in grade 6.
- Per the [Louisiana Student Standards](#), in grades 6-8, narrative elements may include establishing a context, situating events in a time and place, developing a point of view, and developing characters' motives, in addition to the grades 3-5 narrative elements: establishing a situation; organizing a logical event sequence; describing scenes, objects, or people; developing characters' personalities; and using dialogue as appropriate. The elements to be assessed are expressed in the grade-level standard W3.